Still Here

Finding people who cannot ask for help, in the first days after a disaster

Problem analysis and proposed solution (2-pager) · Prototype: see link supplied with this document

Still Here

1. The problem and why we chose it

After a mass disaster, half the population may be gone and the rest are shaken, short of food and connectivity. Help goes to people who can *ask*: those with a phone, signal and a voice. Some of the most vulnerable cannot ask at all: a baby alone in a flat, a bedridden elder, a person with a disability, someone whose carer has vanished. Someone else usually knows they exist: a neighbour, a relative in another city, a nurse with a patient list. That knowledge has nowhere to go.

Why this one. We compared several gaps (supplies, shelter, family tracing, rumours). We chose this because (a) the cost of delay is highest: a child without water has hours, not days; (b) it is the gap existing channels miss, since social posts and helplines reward people who can speak for themselves; (c) it is solvable with ordinary people, because a neighbour within walking distance is the only resource that exists on Day 1; (d) it has a hard design tension worth solving: **the same address that saves a child also invites a thief or kidnapper.** We therefore built the product around who sees what, and when.

2. Who it is for

- **Primary: the responder**, a neighbour who is shaken, on foot, with one hand free and a few spare hours. If responders do not turn up nothing else matters, so their screens get the most care.
- **Reporters**: a relative far away, a nurse, a neighbour behind a locked door. They use one short report form.
- **Never a user: the person in need.** They cannot use an app. Every screen is written about them, not to them.
- **Care staff and local groups**: vouch for helpers and see cases that nobody has claimed.

3. The product and how it solves the problem

A light web app (plain files, nothing to download) that runs one loop: **report → someone goes → they record what is needed → someone is named as responsible.** Everything else is deliberately left out.

Feature	What it does	Why (the reason it exists)
4-step report	Who, what is wrong, how long without care, where. Takes under a minute.	A frightened reporter will abandon a long form; those four answers are the minimum to rank urgency.
Staged reveal of location	Nearby list shows only "small child, no food or water, ~400 m". Street appears after "I'll go"; flat and door only on "I'm outside the building".	A map of pins is the obvious design and the one that helps predators most. Commitment gates detail.
Preview before sending	Reporter sees exactly what strangers will and will not see.	People share sensitive details only if they understand the limits.
Photos released last	Reporter-supplied, shrunk, hidden in the list, shown only at the door after commitment, off on weak signal.	A photo helps find the right person in a building and is also the most sensitive item.
One open visit per helper, 90-minute hold, logged reveals, vouched helpers	A helper holds one case at a time; each reveal is recorded with their name; local groups vouch for helpers. Child cases ask for a second person.	Limits misuse and creates accountability. It reduces risk; it does not remove it, and we say so.
Trust through consequences, not blocking	Reporter says how they know; repeat and staff reports are labelled; "nobody here, no blame" closes in one tap; empty addresses lower a reporter's reliability.	Requiring verification first costs lives. Wrongly ignoring a baby costs far more than a wasted walk.
Visit cannot close without a name and a time	"Done" is disabled until someone is named responsible and a next check is set. Otherwise the case returns to the list with findings.	Free-text notes are written and never read. The danger on Day 2 is people being abandoned after one visit.
Works with no signal	Taps are saved on the phone and sent later; with no data, a pre-written SMS is offered.	Networks fail in the disaster itself; a tool that needs signal fails the people it is for.
Visible urgency score	Sum of who + what is wrong + hours since care, shown with colour, shape and words.	Helpers can disagree with it and see why; it also works for colour-blind or hurried users.
Care-staff board and overdue flags	Unclaimed, "needs two" and overdue cases are listed for coordinators.	Shows where volunteers are short and where follow-up is slipping.

Opening story and plain language	Short opening scene, then simple wording throughout.	Helps first-time visitors grasp the stakes quickly; the story is not needed to use the tool.

4. Key decisions and what we rejected

- **Rejected: a public map.** Fastest to build, but it is a target list.
- **Rejected: verify before a report counts.** A delay costs lives; consequences after the fact keep reports honest without slowing the first one.
- **Rejected: free notes at the end of a visit.** Replaced with a mandatory owner and next-check time.
- **Rejected: app-store install or login.** Anyone with a basic browser, even offline, must be able to use it.

5. How we will know it works

Measure	Target / meaning
Time from report to a person at the door, by urgency	Under 60 minutes for "go now" cases
Closed visits with a named owner and next-check time	100% (enforced by the product)
Next checks done on time	The key number: shows whether people were abandoned on Day 2
"Nobody here" rate per reporter; addresses revealed with no visit	Early signs of false reports or misuse
Cases unclaimed after 3 hours	The true volunteer shortfall, to direct recruitment

We do **not** count downloads, time in app or reports submitted: more use is not more safety.

6. Risks and limits (honest view)

- A determined thief can still lie their way in; staging, logging, vouching and the second-person rule reduce but do not remove this.
- Volunteer supply is the real bottleneck; the product exposes it but cannot create helpers.
- The prototype is a visual representation only: data is simulated and not connected to live services.